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The witch shakes her arm, releasing Eifer, and then—

Matilda: Hmph! Caught you!
You know it's past curfew...

Erick is pinned to the ground, as if weighed down by a pile of stones.

Erick: Now's your chance. Run, you idiots!

The two snap out of it and run into the darkness.

The "Great" Storyteller: They look back, catching a glimpse of our hero's brave resistance.

The "Great" Storyteller: Until their vision is obscured by the night's mist...

It didn't take long for punishment to arrive.

The corridor is empty and silent. Having been punished, Erick stands alone by the classroom door. Her stomach growls.

She glances at her shoes, idly picks her nose, and stares out the window at the dimming twilight. The orange afterglow has reached her knees.

There's a sudden rustling sound from around the corner.

Erick: A jarl never ever gets scared! Come out now! I mean— you'd better show yourself, or else...

From the corner of the hallway, two little heads pop out like rabbits.

Golden Key Sancho: Are you okay?

Erick's bravely puffed chest finally deflates.

Golden Key Sancho: I snuck you some fried cod... You must be starving.

She grabs the offered meal, devouring it like a bear starved through the winter.

Effie: ...Why did you help us?

Erick: (Munching) Because I can't let my future crew fall into another's hands. It was nothing, really. Being a jarl means more than just giving orders; you have to take on responsibility too.

Erick: Even the most powerful of jarls will eventually fall from grace if they avoid their personal responsibilities and simply order others around.

Golden Key Sancho & Effie: ...Wow!

Erick: I heard that in ancient times, there was a king who ruled over the biggest forest in the world...

Listening intently, Sancho and Eifer gradually lower themselves to the floor until they are fully seated, utterly mesmerized by her vivid storytelling.

From the fading rays of the twilight sun to the silvery glow of moonlight, night gracefully arrives.

Their eyes glow brightly. They swallow hard, absorbing the tales of greatness, wonder, and the incredible.